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Multifaceted culture of Japan

Return task 6

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1 Introduktion

Japan is a mountainous island nation in the Pacific Ocean in East Asia, from Sea of the Okhotskt to the East China Sea. The scripting marks of the name of the nation have the meaning “the source of the sun” or “the root of the sun.” That is why Japan is sometimes called as “a country of rising sun”, which is also described in the flag of Japan.

Japan consists of 3000 islands, the biggest ones are Honshu, Hokkaido, Shikoku, and Kyushu. The capital, Tokyo is the biggest settlement center of Japan. The Greater Tokyo Area is the most populous area in the world, with more than 37.4 million residents. There are almost 126 million residents in Japan in total.

After World War 2, there was huge economical increasement in Japan. Happenings like this has been experienced nowhere in the world earlier, so it has been called “the Japanese economic miracle”. Japanese brands and products, such as cars and machines are very well-known with high quality, and popular all over the world.

The distinctive culture of Japan and manners of Japanese is related to its stages and periods of history and to different religions, its location as an island nation whose own traditional culture has not been contaminated much by other cultures of the world and climatic and challenging geographic conditions, too.

The reason last mentioned has caused to the situation where the population has focused to areas which is suitable for settlement, on the coasts and plain lands, because majority of the area of Japan is mountainous and not suitable for settlement. Versatile Japan is one of the most interesting and memorable travel destinations of the world!

2 General information about Japan

2.1 Geography, climate, and nature

Japan is in the Pacific Ring of Fire, at the junction of the continental plates. Due to this instability, there are lot of earthquakes, tsunamis and volcanic activity in Japan. Most of the total area of Japan is mountainous area, about 70-80 percent, and almost as large area of that is also covered by forests. These areas are not suited for settlement, so the habitable zones, mainly in coastal areas, have extremely high population densities. Because of the location and form of Japan, consisting of four bigger and thousands of smaller mainly mountainous islands, surrounding by Oceans, give to geography of Japan its own distinctive features. Climatically, Japan has four clear seasons and in fact five, if also the annual raining period, monsoon, is calculated to include it. The weather is mostly mild but varies quite a lot depending on the season and area. On the northernmost parts of the country, there are long and cold and snowy winters with a humid continental climate. Correspondingly, in the southern parts of the country, especially on southernmost and furthest islands from the mainland like Ryukyu whose biggest island is Okinawa and in Nanpo too, have a subtropical climate where significant features in the climate there are warm winter, hot summer and very heavy rains, especially during the rainy season. The nature is versatile, varying from lush subtropic zone vegetation to more barren mountains and to ultimate north of the country, to much more cooler conditions and coniferous forests. Japan has a very diverse animal and plant species. One of the most well-known Japanese plants are wild blossom cherry trees or Sakura trees in Japanese, full of pink flowers in the spring.

2.2 History, languages, and religions

The history of Japan has traditionally been broken down at least 13 or more special periods, and their subperiods. It has been researched, that first marks of civilization in Japan area is about 10 000 BCE, beginning the Jomon culture. The first Inhabitants were hunters and foragers. It is supposed that they came to Japan islands mainly from areas of Korea and southeast Asia. After

Jomon culture was period called Yaoi perioid, about 200 BCE, known also of ceramics like Jomon culture. A population expanded little by little, new skills were learned such as rice cultivating, bronze and iron making and fabric production. About year 200 began Kofun period led by Yamato clan and the reunification of fragmented country began until by the end of year 300 Yamato has risen a stabile kingdom with connections with China and Korea.

The authority of Yamato decreased at the 5 th century and Buddhism began its spreading to Japan from Korea. The next bigger entity of periods is classic period, from years 500 to the end of 11 th century. Buddhism expanded and many culture things like literature, arts, philosophy, sciences and writing system were learned from Chinese culture.

In the fourth and ninth centuries many kingdoms and tribes of Japan were united under the central government, whose nominal control was the Emperor of Japan, like nowadays. Since that the religions in Japan were a mixture of original polytheistic Shinto practices and Buddhism; there are very little other religions such a Christian or Islam in Japan also these days.

in these times of feodalism Kyoto became capital of Japan and the emperors administrative central. Strong military families got more authority in 1100. Since 1200 the authority of emperor was only to be a symbolic and provinces were led by commanders of army. The Portuguese arrived in Japan in 1543 and began a period known as the Nanban trade period. During this time, Japan did foreign trade with Westerners who brought firearms and Christianity to Japan, among other things. After number of wars Japan became into unified state about year 1600. During next 250 years in the years of Tokugawa-dynasty, Japan isolated of rest of the world until European war ships penetrated to the harbors of Japan for doing trade contracts.

The opening of Japan to the outside world affected so that the dominion was focused for emperor, who began big social modernizations. During a relative short time, Japan developed to the biggest military and economic power in East Asia.

At the years of World War 2, Japan fought on the side of losers, with Germany, Italy. The militarism and need to conquer new areas were significant and important for Japan these times.

USA opposed the aims of Japan in the Pacific Ocean and declared a trade embargo to Japan, which caused the sudden and destructive air attack to navy base of Pearl Harbor of USA by Japanese. USA declared a war to Japan, called the war of Pacific Ocean. Eventually, the World War 2 end, when USA dropped two atomic bombs to Hiroshima and Nagasaki in year 1945. After the long and hard War with USA, there began rebuilding during many years in Japan. Little by little Japan became again one of the most important countries in East Asia. The economical increasement was in the 1960's, 1970’s and 1980’s so big, that Japan was considered as an economic miracle never seen earlier.

2.3 Population, ethnic groups, and languages

Japan is one of the most densely populated countries in the world. When the population have strongly increased by better standard of living majority of the people have been packed to areas close to jobs and close to services – in other words out of mountains to areas suitable for living conditions and possibilities. That has caused extremely effective urbanization and centralizing the population to relatively small areas, like to areas of big metropolises such as Tokyo, Yokohama, and other coastal cities. On the slopes of mountains is cultivated rice and average density of population is relatively low on mountainous and forest areas.

A significant feature related to Japan is its ethnic and linguistic homogeny, about 98,5 percent of the population is Japanese. There are also smaller ethnic minorities such as Ainu aboriginals in northern parts, habitants of Ryuky islands and biggest social minority of Japan called Burakumin, who, in the feudal period, did work considered “dirty” by others. The rest of the population consists other citizens like Chinese and Koreans.

Japanese is extremely difficult language to learn, and it is talked only in Japan. Japanese is written by three different character set, which are byte alphabets called Hiragana and Katakana and the third one called Khanji ideogram set which is Chinese origin. The writing system entity consists of blend of these three ones of marking system. There are about ten thousand of Kanji writing marks, that are probably the most difficult thing to learn by Westerns. The most common ones of them, 2136 characters, is taught in Japan during the 12 first school years. Japanese is mother tongue for 128 million Japanese. English skills are quite low level in general causing mostly of the perfect difference of languages, the less importance to teach English, studying methods and strong homogeneous of Japanese own culture.

2.4 Livelihood, standard of living and health care

By the economic increasement, Japan has become one of the biggest industry, research, economical and well-being countries in the world, whose brands and products are well known all over the world. Japan is one of the biggest manufacturers and users of industrial robots in the world, for example. Japan is the world's third largest nominal GDP after the United States and China. After the World War 2, the standard of living of Japan rose dramatically effected by economic increment never seen before. The most remarkable branches in economics are banking and insurance, real property business, retail, transport, and telecommunications. Japan has a

large industrial capacity: it is the world's most advanced manufacturers of motor vehicles, electrical equipment, machinery, metals, ships, chemicals, textiles, and food. Although only 15 percent of total area of Japan is suitable for agriculture, the harvests per area unit are biggest in the world. On the other hand, state supports effectively small agriculture sector. Rice cultivating and fishing are especially important for the food production in Japan. The life expectancy in Japan is one of the highest in the world. Only three percent of population are fat due to vegetarian food and lot of exercise.

2.5 Form of government and decision making

Japan is constitutional monarchy, whose ceremonial figurehead is The Emperor of Japan. Real political authority is used by prime minister and parliament elected by folk. Japan has divided to 47 prefectures. Even though Japan is uniform state otherwise, local governments have quite a lot of autonomy in any branches.

2.6 Educational system, science, and research

Since 1947 compulsory education has consisted of nine years of school. Almost all students continue in high school and 75,9 percent to university, school of economics, or some tertiary education institution. Japan is one of the leader states in scientific research, technology, engineering, and medical research branches. Japan has had a significant affect to development of electronics, industry robots, optics, semiconductors, and metals.

2.7 Tourism, trade, and foreign relations

Japan is unbelievable versatile traveling destination country. The number of travelers is rising all the time. There are lot of to experience and to see in Japan, such as big cities, beautiful gardens, museums, and temples. Kyoto is by far the best travel destination for those interested in these Japanese traditional attractions. One of the most popular sightseeing is the holy Fuji-mountain, of course. Japan has close economic and military relationship with its most important ally USA. Since 1956 Japan has been a member of UN. The most important export countries are China, USA, South-Korea, Hong Kong, and Thailand.

3 General information about Japanese culture

3.1 Customs, manners, traditions, and taboos

Although Asian culture is very different compared to western culture in general, the Japanese culture of customs is in own level, however. Due to its colorful history and special geographic location and conditions the Japanese culture has developed in peace. Many of these special features will be a surprise for Western travelers. It is highly recommended to find out a few basics before traveling to Japan avoid extra embarrassing issues and situations in the country. On the other hand, unusuality and uniqueness of the Japanese culture will do the trip especially exotic and memorable.

Japanese are ultimate polite persons. That is shown in all the daily interaction and communication. All the bowing and thanking by Japanese may be amazing and puzzling at first, but on the other hand the atmosphere like this does the travelling very nice and effortless. All the travelers in Japan should to remember good polite and manners also by themselves, too. *"Sumimasen*, translated into excuse me is the word which is never used too much in Japan. It is as an essential part of thanking. Repeating it and bowing is one of the basics of good polite and manners in Japan.

Using the number four is avoided as much as possible in Japan, because it is the unlucky number, as number 13 in Western world, but with bigger meaning. For example, taking four flowers as a gift is disliked. In addition, the marking of fourth floor has often been omitted from elevators and floor numbering. Things are always divided with number three, because dividing with number two causes bad luck too.

On the other hand, gifts given on visits are almost obligatory in Japan – the more beautiful packet the better. If gift is given by Japanese, remember always to thank greatly.

Japanese honor extremely much food and eating moments. It is not acceptable to eat standing or walking. Before food is always wished *"itadakimasu"* for all others in the table. After the meal it is also polite to say *"gochisousama deshita"* to the host or hostess or the staff of restaurant. Eating is always done with sticks. Tips are never be taken in Japanese restaurants, although it is very usual in Western.

When traveler has gotten a call to visit from Japanese, there are many important things to remember. At first, as earlier mentioned, acquire a suitable gift. At first, as earlier mentioned, acquire a suitable gift. Secondly, always take off your shoes before going in, shoe tips towards the outdoor. Japanese give you indoor shoes during your visit. Thirdly, avoid telling

your own opinion of something with Japanese. Japanese have so called two opinions, *"hone",* which is real opinion and *"tahamae",* which is public opinion, used in the situations where may be possible that own real opinion will offend somebody. Fourth, avoid the direct eye contact with Japanese, because it is seen to be impolite.

3.2 Sports

Japan's national sport has traditionally been sumo wrestling, which is still one of the most popular sports in the country. Other traditional sport such as karate, judo and kendo are widely practiced and watched greatly, too. Nowadays the baseball is one of the most popular sport in Japan; but soccer and winter sport have also risen its popularity. Japan was host country in summer Olympics of Tokyo 1964, Winter Olympics of Sapporo 1972 and Winter Olympics of Nagano 1998.

3.3 Foods

Nowadays the basic raw material of Japanese kitchen is rice. The foods are light and cooked as little as possible. The quality and looks is very important things related to food. The importance of fish and vegetables is big yet, although the consumption of meat has achieved the amount of consumption of fish. The popular Japanese fish foods are sushi, sashimi, and tempura, which is Portuguese origin. Soy sauce and soy-based tofu and miso are usual food materials, also noodles and chicken foods are popular. As a food drink is often beer and green tea. Popular traditional alcoholic drink is sake and stronger drink shochu.

3.4 Architecture, art, music, and literature

One of the important concepts in Japanese architecture and other art is empty space "*ma"*, which is inextricably linked to Shintoism. The buildings and the nature are seen as an entity, and he borders of them are wanted to merge. A traditional art, music and literature follows the same principle and contains strong influences on history, religion, and the worldview of the Japanese.

4 Working life and business culture

4.1 Working time and working ethic

One of the most known things related to Japanese is the work life culture of Japan. After World War 2 there have required hard work discipline and long working hours. Although Japan has become more Western country nowadays, long working days are still usual in Japan, and overtime is not paid. Working sick is common, too. Employment relationships have traditionally been a lifelong commitment, although intensified competition has brought even more Western features and faster employee turnover.

4.2 Rules in business life

The Japanese business life is very different compared to Western counterpart. Japanese company is like a big family, where community is very important thing with employees and partners. There are accurate etiquette rules in Japanese working culture, which may be extremely surprising to Finns. First impression and details are always important, so the relevant dressing is a first issue which should pay attention by Westerns. The Japanese business world has a strict dress code: a suit and tie for men, a suit jacket for women, and an optional skirt or straight pants. In addition, giving gifts is also very important in business life.

Bowing is ultimate important in the business culture, as a gesture of respect to business partner. Giving a business card is always very important. Japanese make decisions more slowly and they use the silence as a method to affect. Rushing and nervousness is negative thing, according to Japanese. The silence usually means two things in communication, Japanese partner are concentrating accurately or there is something which disturb to trade partner in the situation. Japanese use to often repeat a word “hai” during the discussion, which is thought and translated easily to word “yes” by Westerns. In fact, that means not a word yes usually, but mostly it is only a mark, that Japanese is listening.

Compliance with the protocol may be extremely difficult to Westerns. The Japanese, in turn, see that protocols make the life easier, if all the people have same knowledge of relevant manners and how to polite in different situations.

Using a good interpreter is especially useful with Japanese. Then also the wordless communication, gestures, and indirect meanings of things of discussion with Japanese, are opened better to Westerns. Post-meeting or post-work evening suppers and informal occasions are very important to the Japanese and have a ritual role in Japanese work communities. It is very necessary also for Westerners to take part in them, for developing business relationships with Japanese as good as possible.

5 Conclusion

It can be said with certainty that Japan and Japanese culture are one of the most special cultures in the world. Getting into extremely big cultural shock is certain if you don't know about Japanese culture at all. To understanding of it at least a little, it is very important to learn enough about history of Japan and certain things and features related to manners, attitudes, world view and religions of Japanese in their ordinary life and of rules of business culture. Japanese are extremely homogenous nation, and in their opinion, nobody others cannot be a real Japanese except only a human born in Japan despite of good language skills, Japanese manners, and other necessary skills in Japan. To survive of many kinds of significantly different politeness rules, manners, and large amount of people, to avoid the worst mistakes and embarrassing situations, it is more than recommendable to be aware and learn enough about all these issues beforehand. I am sure, that after good preparation the traveler will get one of the most memorable experience.